KEY TOPIC 3: ELIZABETHAN SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF EXPLORATION, 1558-88

Paper 2: Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88



COURSE TEXTBOOK

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L1: KT3.1: Education and leisure

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Understand the purpose of Elizabethan education and the influence of Humanist thinking and the printing press.
- [ ] Analyse how the schooling system (Petty schools, Grammar schools, and Universities) was strictly divided by class and gender.
- [ ] Explain the differences in leisure and sports between the nobility and the lower classes, including the universal popularity of 'cruel sports'.
- [ ] Evaluate the reasons for the sudden explosion of the Elizabethan theatre and why it provoked such fierce opposition from Puritans and city authorities.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Who led the Spanish Armada?

2. What was the Armada's plan?

3. What tactic did the English use to break the Spanish defensive formation at Calais?

4. What was the decisive sea battle of the Armada called?

5. What role did the weather play in defeating the Armada?

6. What did Drake do in Cadiz in 1587?

7. When was Mary, Queen of Scots executed?

8. What was the Treaty of Nonsuch?

9. Who was Francis Walsingham?

10. What was the Book of Common Prayer?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

Grammar School | Petty School | Humanism | Literacy | Pastimes | The Theatre

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source S1: Elizabethan Theatre



A sketch of the Swan Theatre in London, showing the stage and audience galleries.

In Elizabethan England, education was not about equality or social mobility; it was strictly about preparing people for their expected roles in life. The system was completely dominated by the social hierarchy. However, the period did see a slight expansion in education. This was largely driven by **Humanism**, championed by scholars like Roger Ascham (Elizabeth's own tutor), which acted as a definitive *catalyst for* educational reform. Humanists believed that society could be improved through learning and that the wealthy had a duty to be highly educated to effectively serve the state. Furthermore, the growth of Protestantism encouraged people to learn to read the Bible in English, a trend rapidly accelerated by the invention of the printing press, which made books significantly cheaper.

Q1. What was the overarching social and political objective of education in Elizabethan England?

Despite these changes, education remained a strict privilege. * **Petty Schools:** Children from the lower-middle classes (like prosperous farmers or craftsmen) might attend local Petty schools from the age of six, using a **hornbook** to learn basic literacy and maths. Girls rarely progressed beyond this stage; their education was heavily restricted to domestic skills (spinning, brewing, needlework) to prepare them for marriage. * **Grammar Schools:** For the sons of the gentry, merchants, and wealthy professionals, Grammar schools provided a rigorous education from age seven to fourteen. The curriculum was dominated by Latin, Greek, and classical philosophy. Discipline was incredibly harsh, with teachers frequently using the cane. * **University:** England had only two universities: Oxford and Cambridge. These were reserved for the sons of the nobility and the brightest scholars, focusing on geometry, music, philosophy, and law. Ultimately, literacy rates rose during Elizabeth's reign (by 1603, roughly 30% of men could read), but the stark inequality remained: only around **10% of women** achieved literacy, and the vast majority of the labouring poor remained entirely uneducated, as their children were needed to work the land.

Q2. The 'But/Because/So' Strategy: Complete the sentence: Grammar schools expanded rapidly under Elizabeth to teach Latin and rhetoric, BUT...

Leisure in Elizabethan England was *intrinsically linked* to a person's social class. The nobility possessed vast amounts of free time and wealth. Their sports were highly exclusive, including hunting on horseback, hawking (using trained birds of prey), fencing, and 'real tennis' (a complex, indoor version of the modern game). Conversely, the lower classes engaged in brutal, chaotic pastimes. The most famous was **mob football**, a violently aggressive game played between neighbouring villages with almost no rules, which frequently resulted in severe injuries or even death. However, one area of leisure united all classes: **Cruel Sports**. Bear-baiting and bull-baiting (where a chained bear or bull was attacked by a pack of specially bred fighting dogs) were massively popular. Purpose-built arenas, like the Bear Garden in London, drew massive crowds, and even Queen Elizabeth herself was an enthusiastic fan, frequently commanding private exhibitions at court.

Q3. How did Elizabethan leisure pursuits reinforce social divisions between the nobility and ordinary labourers?

The most revolutionary cultural shift of the era was the explosion of the theatre. Before Elizabeth's reign, wandering 'strolling players' primarily performed religious mystery plays. Elizabeth banned these plays in the 1570s to prevent Catholic and Protestant conflict. This ban acted as a powerful catalyst for playwrights—such as Christopher Marlowe and William Shakespeare—to write exciting, secular (non-religious) plays, such as comedies and violent tragedies. In 1576, the first purpose-built theatre, **The Theatre**, opened in London, soon followed by The Rose and **The Globe**. The theatre was entirely unique because it mixed all social classes. For just one penny, the poorest citizens (the 'groundlings') could stand in the open-air pit, while the nobility paid to sit in the covered, cushioned galleries above. However,

the theatre provoked intense fury from the Puritans, who argued that it was a den of sin that distracted people from prayer. This anger was *exacerbated* by the location of the theatres; they were built in the 'suburbs' outside the strict control of the City of London's Mayor, meaning they attracted thieves and prostitutes, and contributed heavily to the rapid spread of the bubonic plague. Furthermore, the **1572 Vagabonds Act** meant that actors were treated as criminals unless they had a license from a lord. Consequently, the theatre only survived because it was heavily protected by the Queen and powerful nobles who actively sponsored the acting companies, such as the Earl of Leicester's Men and the Lord Chamberlain's Men.

Q4. Why did the public theatre become such an extraordinarily popular and revolutionary cultural medium in the 1570s and 1580s?

Elizabethan education and leisure were highly effective mirrors of the era's rigid social hierarchy. Education expanded thanks to Humanism, the printing press, and Protestantism, but it remained fundamentally unequal, strictly ring-fencing opportunities based on gender and wealth. Similarly, sports like real tennis and mob football visually separated the elite from the masses. However, the late 16th century also saw the birth of a unified popular culture. Cruel sports and the booming new theatres provided shared spaces where, for a few hours, the glittering nobility and the illiterate groundlings experienced the exact same entertainment, creating a vibrant, albeit highly controversial, cultural golden age.

Q5. Constrained Summary: In two precise sentences, explain how education and leisure reflected the contradictory nature of Elizabethan society.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Discuss with your partner: Did Elizabethan education improve society or simply reinforce class divisions?

L2: KT3.2: The Problem of Poverty

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Understand the economic and demographic causes of the poverty crisis, focusing on population growth, inflation, and the devastating impact of enclosure.
- [ ] Analyse contemporary Tudor attitudes towards the poor, specifically the strict division between the 'deserving' (impotent) and 'undeserving' (able-bodied) poor.
- [ ] Explain the reasons behind the public terror of vagabonds.
- [ ] Evaluate the significance of Elizabeth's changing policies, specifically the 1572 Vagabonds Act and the 1576 Poor Relief Act.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Name two types of schools in Elizabethan England.

2. What was a typical subject studied at Grammar school?

3. What was a popular cruel animal sport during this period?

4. Name one famous Elizabethan theatre.

5. Were women allowed to act on the Elizabethan stage?

6. Who led the Spanish Armada?

7. What was the Battle of Gravelines?

8. What phrase did Drake use to describe his attack on Cadiz?

9. What was the Babington Plot (1586)?

10. What was the 'Great Chain of Being'?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: *Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

Enclosure | Impotent Poor | Able-Bodied Poor | Vagabond | Poor Rate | 1601 Poor Law

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

Source S1: The Poor Law



An extract from the 1601 Elizabethan Poor Law outlining support for the destitute.

During Elizabeth's reign, the number of people living in extreme poverty rapidly increased. This crisis was driven by a 'perfect storm' of economic and demographic factors. The foundational cause was **population growth**; the population of England rose dramatically from roughly 3 million in 1551 to over 4 million by 1601. This population boom acted as a direct *catalyst for* rampant inflation. Because there were more people, the demand for food and housing skyrocketed, causing prices to rise much faster than wages. Consequently, ordinary labourers found it increasingly impossible to afford basic survival necessities, a situation severely *exacerbated* by a series of disastrously bad harvests in the 1570s that caused acute food shortages. Furthermore, poverty was *intrinsically linked* to the agricultural shift known as **enclosure**. To make more money, wealthy landowners fenced off shared village land to breed sheep for the lucrative European wool trade. Sheep farming required only one shepherd, whereas traditional crop farming required dozens of labourers. This led to mass evictions, forcing thousands of unemployed, desperate farmers to leave their villages and migrate to towns and cities looking for work, rapidly swelling the ranks of the urban poor. Finally, when the English cloth trade collapsed due to a trade embargo with Antwerp, thousands of weavers and spinners lost their jobs overnight.

Q1. Identify the primary economic and demographic factors that caused a severe poverty crisis in Elizabethan England.

The Elizabethan government did not believe it was their job to help the poor; they believed everyone had a fixed, God-given place in the social hierarchy. They strictly divided the poor into two categories. The **'Impotent Poor'** (the sick, elderly, and orphans) were viewed with sympathy as the 'deserving poor' and were helped by local charity and the Church. However, the **'Able-Bodied Poor'** were viewed with intense suspicion and hatred. The authorities believed that if you were physically capable of working but had no job, you were simply lazy and dangerous. The most hated of all were **vagabonds**—homeless beggars who wandered the country. The public was terrified of them. Popular pamphlets, like those written by Thomas Harman, warned the public about deceptive tricksters, such as the 'Counterfeit Crank' (who faked epileptic fits with soap in their mouth to get sympathy money) or the 'Clapper Dudgeon' (who tied arsenic to their skin to create fake, bleeding sores).

Q2. Causal Linkage: How did the agricultural practice of 'enclosure' directly fuel the growth of urban vagrancy?

Initially, the government's approach to vagabonds was purely brutal. However, as the crisis deepened, the government realised that the threat of mass starvation could lead to a catastrophic peasant rebellion. They had to take national action. * **The 1572 Vagabonds Act:** This law was heavily punitive. It stated that any vagabond caught wandering could be brutally whipped and have a hole burned through their right ear. If caught a third time, they could be executed. However, it was historically highly significant because it officially introduced the **national Poor Rate**—a compulsory local tax to raise money for the deserving poor. It acknowledged for the first time that the government, not just the Church, had a duty to help the vulnerable. ***The 1576 Poor Relief Act:*** *This act was a revolutionary turning point. It finally recognised a harsh economic reality: some able-bodied people genuinely* wanted* to work but simply could not find any. It ordered JPs to provide raw materials (like wool and hemp) for the unemployed to work with and sell. For those who still stubbornly refused to work, it ordered the creation of **'Houses of Correction'** (strict workhouses) where they would be punished and forced to labour.

Q3. Why did the Elizabethan ruling class regard wandering 'sturdy beggars' with intense terror?

The Elizabethan era completely transformed how England dealt with poverty. The demographic explosion and the greed of enclosure destroyed the traditional, rural way of life, forcing thousands onto the road as vagabonds. Fear of these 'masterless men' initially led to brutal, violent legislation. However, the sheer

scale of the crisis forced Elizabeth's government to undergo a profound ideological shift. By introducing a compulsory Poor Rate in 1572 and actively providing raw materials for the unemployed in 1576, Elizabeth's government laid the very first, tentative foundations of a national welfare state—not out of modern compassion, but out of a desperate, pragmatic need to maintain social order and prevent rebellion.

Q4. The 'But/Because/So' Strategy: Complete the sentence: Tudor authorities initially attempted to eradicate poverty through brutal physical punishments, BUT...

Pair & Share Activity

Q5. Discuss with your partner: Why did poverty increase so rapidly during Elizabeth's reign?

L3: KT3.3: Exploration and voyages of discovery

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Understand the factors that prompted Elizabethan exploration, focusing on new technology, expanding trade, and privateering.
- [ ] Explain the reasons for, and the immense geopolitical significance of, Francis Drake's circumnavigation of the globe.
- [ ] Analyse the reasons behind Walter Raleigh's attempts to colonise Virginia.
- [ ] Evaluate the intersecting reasons for the catastrophic failure of the Virginia colonies, weighing poor planning against Native American resistance and the Spanish war.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What was a 'vagrant' or 'vagabond'?

2. What were the 'deserving poor'?

3. What were the 'idle poor'?

4. What was the 1572 Vagabonds Act?

5. What caused poverty to rise in this period?

6. What was a typical subject studied at a Grammar school?

7. Were women allowed to act on stage?

8. What tactic did the English use to break the Spanish formation at Calais?

9. What was a 'privateer'?

10. What was the Act of Supremacy?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: *Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:*

Circumnavigation | Astrolabe | Quadrant | Log and Line | Mercator Projection | Golden Hind

Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Source S1: The Golden Hind



A replica of the Golden Hind, the ship Francis Drake used to circumnavigate the globe.

Before Elizabeth's reign, England was a relatively minor power focused entirely on Europe. However, by the 1570s, a surge of exploration transformed England's global reach. This was driven by a combination of factors: 1. **Expanding Trade:** Historically, England relied entirely on exporting wool to Antwerp. When relations with Spain deteriorated and the Antwerp market collapsed, English merchants desperately needed to find new, global markets. This acted as a direct *catalyst for* the creation of overseas trading companies, such as the Muscovy Company (trading with Russia) and the Eastland Company. 2. **New Technology:** Exploration was made possible by major advancements in navigation. The **astrolabe** and the quadrant allowed sailors to calculate their exact position at sea. Furthermore, mapmaking vastly improved, with the Mercator projection allowing for highly accurate sea charts. 3. **Ship Design:** English shipbuilders developed the **galleon**. These ships were faster, lower in the water, and featured highly manoeuvrable triangular (lateen) sails, allowing them to sail effectively across treacherous oceans. 4. **Privateering:** The desire for vast, rapid wealth drove sailors to the New World. English privateers aimed to raid the highly lucrative Spanish treasure fleets returning from Central and South America.

Q1. Why did Elizabethan merchants and navigators suddenly turn their attention to global maritime exploration in the 1570s?

In 1577, Sir Francis Drake set sail on a secret mission funded by Elizabeth. His primary goal was to raid Spanish colonies on the Pacific coast of South America, an area the Spanish thought was entirely safe. Forced to keep sailing west to avoid Spanish capture, Drake inadvertently completed a three-year **circumnavigation** of the globe. His journey was highly significant. First, he claimed land in North America (modern-day California), naming it *Nova Albion* for the Queen. Second, he captured a staggering £400,000 of Spanish silver (mostly from the treasure ship *Cacafuego*). When Drake returned, Elizabeth publicly knighted him on the deck of his ship, the *Golden Hind*. This massive insult was *intrinsically linked* to the outbreak of the Anglo-Spanish war, as it proved Elizabeth openly supported piracy.

Q2. Identify two technological developments that enabled Elizabethan sailors to undertake perilous transoceanic voyages.

Elizabeth wanted to establish a permanent English colony in North America to rival Spain's empire, provide a base for privateering, and secure raw materials. In 1584, she gave Sir Walter Raleigh a royal charter to colonise an area he named **Virginia** (in honour of the 'Virgin Queen'). Raleigh did not go himself, but he organised and funded two major expeditions (1585 and 1587) to Roanoke Island. Both attempts ended in absolute disaster due to a combination of factors: ***Poor Planning and Lack of Food:*** *During the 1585 expedition, the English flagship,* The Tiger*, hit a sandbank and let in seawater. This completely ruined their crucial food supplies and the seeds they had brought to plant crops. This immediately forced the English to rely on Native Americans for food, which bred resentment. * **Poor Leadership:** The colony's leaders—specifically Richard Grenville and Ralph Lane—argued constantly. Lane was deeply aggressive and militaristic, prioritizing the hunt for gold over establishing a sustainable farming settlement. * **Native American Resistance:** Driven by English aggression, demands for food, and the devastating spread of European diseases, the local Algonquian tribes fought back. **Chief Wingina** turned entirely against the English, launching attacks that made the colony untenable. * **The Spanish Armada:** The second colonisation attempt in 1587 (which included women and children) was doomed by geopolitical events. Because of the Spanish Armada in 1588, Elizabeth banned all ships from leaving England. This meant that the colony's leader, John White, could not return with vital rescue supplies for three years. When he finally returned in 1590, the entire colony had vanished without a trace, remembered today as the 'Lost Colony'.

Q3. What was the economic and political significance of Sir Francis Drake's voyage aboard the Golden Hind?

The Elizabethan era was the turbulent dawn of the British Empire. Forced outward by the collapse of European trade, English sailors utilised cutting-edge technology and galleon designs to project English power across the globe. While Drake's circumnavigation was a dazzling financial and propaganda triumph that enraged Spain, Raleigh's Virginia campaigns offered a brutal reality check. The failures at Roanoke proved that creating an empire required more than just the piracy of privateers; it required careful logistical planning, farming expertise, and sustainable diplomacy. These harsh lessons, however, laid the essential foundations for the successful Jamestown colony established shortly after Elizabeth's death in 1607.

Q4. The 'But/Because/So' Strategy: Complete the sentence: England achieved spectacular naval glory through privateering in the 1570s and 1580s, BUT...

Pair & Share Activity

Q5. Discuss with your partner: What was the main motivation for Elizabethan exploration?

L4: KT3.4: Raleigh and Virginia

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Understand the significance of Sir Walter Raleigh in planning, promoting, and financing the Virginia colonies.
- [ ] Analyse the economic, political, and strategic reasons for the attempted colonisation of North America.
- [ ] Evaluate the intersecting reasons for the catastrophic failure of the 1585 and 1587 expeditions, weighing poor planning against Native American resistance and the Spanish Armada.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Why did English sailors explore the world?

2. What new technology helped Elizabethan exploration?

3. Who was the first Englishman to circumnavigate the globe (1577-1580)?

4. Who did Elizabeth give a patent to colonize North America in 1584?

5. Why did the first Roanoke settlement (1585) fail?

6. What happened to the second Roanoke settlement (1587)?

7. What caused poverty to rise in the Elizabethan period?

8. What was the 1572 Vagabonds Act?

9. Who led the Spanish Armada?

10. What was the Ridolfi Plot (1571)?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: *Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Royal Charter | Virginia | Roanoke | Algonquian | Manteo and Wanchese | Lost Colony

> *"Sir Walter Raleigh's Royal Charter established a thriving, permanent English metropolis at Roanoke that maintained uninterrupted peace with the local Algonquian tribes."*

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:

Source S1: Roanoke Colony



A map of the failed Roanoke colony in Virginia.

Sir Walter Raleigh was one of Elizabeth's most favoured courtiers. In 1584, Elizabeth granted him a **Royal Charter** to explore and colonise North America. Crucially, Elizabeth refused to let Raleigh lead the expeditions himself; he was too valuable to her at court. Instead, Raleigh's significance lies in his brilliant planning. He raised the massive funds required by persuading merchants to invest, designed the strategy, and brought two Native Americans, **Manteo and Wanchese**, back to England in 1584 to help the English learn the Algonquian language. The colonisation attempt was driven by multiple motives. Economically, England desperately needed a new market for its cloth exports following the collapse of the Antwerp market. Furthermore, establishing a foothold in the Americas was *intrinsically linked* to breaking Spain's lucrative commercial monopoly in the New World. Strategically, a colony in North America would provide a vital, hidden base for English privateers to launch raids against the Spanish treasure fleets.

Q1. Why was Sir Walter Raleigh determined to establish an English colony in North America, and what did he name it?

In 1585, Raleigh sent 107 men to Roanoke, led by the naval commander Richard Grenville and the military governor **Ralph Lane**. It included the brilliant mathematician **Thomas Harriot**, who mapped the area. However, the expedition was doomed from the start. As they arrived, their flagship, *The Tiger*, hit a sandbank and let in seawater. This ruined almost all their food supplies and the seeds they had brought to plant crops. The demographics of the settlers *exacerbated* this disaster: they were mostly soldiers and wealthy gentlemen who lacked the practical farming skills needed to survive. Desperate, the English relied heavily on the local Algonquian tribes for food, depleting the locals' fish weirs and crucial winter stores. Governor Ralph Lane was highly aggressive, treating the Native Americans with suspicion and violence. Furthermore, the English unwittingly brought European diseases to which the locals had no immunity, wiping out whole villages. This acted as a *catalyst for* war. The local leader, **Chief Wingina**, planned to attack the English, but Lane ambushed and killed Wingina first. By 1586, the colony was starving, terrified, and entirely untenable. When Francis Drake sailed past after raiding the Caribbean, the surviving colonists abandoned Roanoke and hitched a ride home with him.

Q2. Causal Linkage: Why did the first settlement at Roanoke in 1585, led by Ralph Lane, collapse within a single year?

Raleigh learned from his mistakes. In 1587, he sent a second expedition led by **John White**. This time, the 117 settlers were mostly families—men, women, and children with practical farming skills—intended to create a peaceful, sustainable community. Tragically, they arrived at the exact same location (Roanoke) where Lane's men had previously slaughtered Wingina. Unsurprisingly, the Native Americans were deeply hostile from the moment they landed. After a colonist was found murdered, John White was forced to sail back to England to beg Raleigh for immediate military and food supplies. White's ability to return was destroyed by the unfolding geopolitical crisis in Europe. In 1588, Elizabeth banned all ships from leaving English ports because every vessel was needed to fight the imminent threat of the Spanish Armada. White was stranded in England for three years. When he finally returned to Roanoke in 1590, the settlement was completely deserted. There were no bodies, just the word **"CROATOAN"** carved into a wooden post. The fate of the colonists remains a mystery to this day.

Q3. How did the composition of the 1587 expedition differ from 1585, and what was the mystery of the 'Lost Colony'?

Raleigh's ambitious dream of a New World empire ended in complete failure. The colonies collapsed due to a lethal intersection of terrible luck (the grounding of *The Tiger*), poor leadership (Lane's aggression), a lack of farming expertise, and the overarching shadow of the Anglo-Spanish war. However, Raleigh's failure was highly significant because it provided the ultimate blueprint for future success. It proved that private funding was not enough and that successful colonisation required massive, state-backed investment and a focus on sustainable farming rather than aggressive military conquest. These harsh lessons laid the foundation for the successful establishment of Jamestown shortly after Elizabeth's death.

Q4. Constrained Summary: Outline the three primary reasons why Raleigh's attempts to colonise Virginia failed in the 1580s.

Pair & Share Activity

Q5. Discuss with your partner: Why did the Roanoke colony fail?